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Joanne Brackeen

Joanne Brackeen was born in Ventura, California on July 26, 1938. A self-taught jazz pianist, she worked in Los Angeles with Dexter Gordon and Charles Lloyd, and moved to New York in 1965. Joanne has recorded her original compositions with Art Blakey, Stan Getz and Joe Henderson and leads her own trio in performances here and abroad.

Joanne was interviewed in New York City on January 10, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming in New York City at the International Association of Jazz Educators. And I'm very pleased to have Joanne Brackeen here. And welcome and thank you very much for coming.

JB: Oh you're welcome.

MR: I'd like to congratulate you on your career so far.

JB: Thank you.

MR: It's an interesting read. And I'd like to venture kind of guess that your composing is just as important as your playing? Perhaps more so?

JB: Well I don't know about that. But it's definitely very important, yeah. I mean a lot of my playing, the development of my playing I feel came out of learning how to play the compositions that I play, and the compositions very often come as spontaneously as improvising does. Parts. I mean I don't just sit down and play and spontaneously that's a composition, although that could happen. But I'll edit and put this here or there. Whatever. But many times when I'm doing parts of a composition I'm playing some things that I've never played before and when I write them down and try to play them again I can't do it.

MR: Isn't that interesting.

JB: So you're coming from another place which is very similar to the place that happens when I am improvising. So I would say they're very, very connected.

MR: Sometimes when you look at a piece of music rhythmically, written down, it does seem harder to play when you're reading it than just in doing it.

JB: Well I didn't mean that, that's definitely true in my case, but I didn't mean just that. No even if you know what that is, it's not like that, it's like somebody else wrote this, how in the world could someone play this. And then in a week or whatever I've got it.

MR: What kind of caught your ear when you were young, that led you down this path?

JB: The sound of the piano. Simple as that. I love the sound of the piano. And it's interesting too because when I hear the sound of the piano I love it, but I also hear a sound of an

orchestra inside the sound of the piano. So I wrote a string quartet, it was very easy for me to play the violin part. It's like I'm already hearing that. So it's something I didn't really notice, but it was there from the beginning, I hear an orchestra there.

MR: I read an interesting little tidbit, that someone said that one of your early influences was Frankie Carle?

JB: Um hmm. Absolutely. Really that was how I learned how to play. I liked his solos. I liked his piano playing. And there was one album, I think it was called "Frankie Carle and his Girlfriends," and so it was like Diane and Charmaine and Louise and I learned these solos note for note when I was eleven. I played them actually. I began performing them.

MR: No kidding?

JB: The whole solos, the whole thing, exactly what you heard on the record, that's what I played. So after doing maybe six months of that, and maybe I did eight or ten of them, I knew how to play the piano.

MR: When you were playing them, I'm trying to figure out how to say this, did you know what you were playing from a harmonic standpoint?

JB: I just heard. I still, that's how I go now, what I do now. People say "What's that" and, "what's that," and I say well it's the music, here it is, this is what it is. And I still don't have a definite definition of everything.

MR: Interesting. When you do a lead sheet on a new composition.

JB: I try. I try.

MR: You come as close as the chord language will allow?

JB: Well sometimes it's like a one chord over another chord, but the other chord has maybe it's over the third of that chord, but you also have to have the tonic, the root of that in there too. So it's like well you want the E flat but if you called it an E flat that would be on the bottom but it's not. So then I've got three chords there. So there are different ways to notate it by the time I look at that I would never just spontaneously figure it out. So I do what I can.

MR: Was Los Angeles — that's where you're from, correct?

JB: Um hum. Actually born in Ventura.

MR: Was it a good musical atmosphere to grow up in?

JB: Well it had been. It was before I was there. And a little bit was still left. There was a lot of jazz there when I was too young to —

MR: Central Avenue and that —

JB: Yeah. There was a lot. But there was a little bit left by the time I was fifteen, sixteen, seventeen, and I got out to hear that. I heard Art Blakey, I heard Johnny Griffin, and of course I heard Coltrane and I heard a lot of things, McCoy Tyner. It wasn't like New York. And I always had a feeling that I wanted to be in New York, since I was six years

old I was drawing — and I've never heard or seen anything — but I was drawing these apartment buildings with little mice sticking out of them for people, like a lot of people in every window. It was very funny.

MR: Neat.

JB: Yeah.

MR: How did your parents feel about your — the direction you seemed to be embracing in music?

JB: Well they didn't seem to think too much about it until they started hearing me on the radio and then they began to get a bit proud about it, when their friends said, "Oh I heard your daughter on the radio." They liked that.

MR: And I read you played with quite a good list of tenor players early on.

JB: Um hum.

MR: Harold Land and that group.

JB: Yeah, they were from California, Harold Land, Teddy Edwards, Charles Lloyd. Those are the people that you would recognize. There were other people who just kind of that lived in this area that you wouldn't have heard of so much. Walter Benton was one of the major people there. Ray Graziano. There were other people but the people that we are speaking of are the ones that are kind of known all over.

MR: Uh huh. So in order to play with these musicians, what kind of preparation did you undergo. Was it — did someone tell you to learn the standards and all that?

JB: No. Nobody told me anything.

MR: No kidding.

JB: It was very weird. They didn't have really schools that much. There was one school called the Westlake College of Music. And my parents took me there when I was fourteen and I remember studying a little bit with a piano player named Dave Robertson and also one named Gene Garf. And I remember Gene Garf liked Art Tatum a lot and I didn't at that time. And they would give me a tune a week or something, I would learn a tune, and it would be a standard. They didn't say anything and it really, there was no way that you learned scales and how to play on things, they just said here's a tune, you know, improvise on it. So I did. It was kind of hard. But I learned how to do it. I don't know how I did. And then of course I heard Charlie Parker and that did it for me when I heard that. You know whatever Art Tatum had done for the previous piano teacher, Charlie Parker did that for me. And then of course Bud Powell. So those were my favorites right when I was like seventeen, eighteen. And I used to transcribe the whole thing you know, so I could play it on the record, like a record like that over there, that's what we had are 33s. And I'd put the record on, transcribe the Bird solo and the Bud solo, so I could play the whole thing. And it would be a half a tone sharp so if it was in the key of F it would

be G flat. But you know the funny thing about not knowing anything too much and not having many teachers was that I didn't know that was hard, or I didn't think too much, it was just something I really liked to do. And I thought that the feeling of the music was incredible. I still feel that way when I hear Bird and Bud. Nothing left. So those two are really amazing. A lot of times you hear music, of course I have a different opinion of Art Tatum, I love him now too. But sometimes you know you hear music and it seems to — it changes. It doesn't but you change and so it sounds changed. But they didn't.

MR: Do you think Tatum was perhaps too technical for your ears at the time? Or can you think back on that?

JB: I don't know what it was. I kind of liked the rhythmical feeling of what Bird and Diz and many other people too, Tommy Flanagan was one of the first people I heard, Sonny Rollins, I just thought they were fantastic. I like the rhythmical essence there, and while Art Tatum had it, he would kind of venture off of it and I'm like, now why is he doing that? But then later on, as you get to know the piano better, he is totally amazing. And I love him. And I can listen to him any mood at any time.

MR: Um hum. I like the statement you pointed out just a moment ago though about the not knowing something was supposed to be difficult.

JB: Yes. No, there were no teachers then.

MR: Right. So it didn't get in your way, that you had to play in the key of G flat.

JB: No, I didn't know.

MR: Very interesting. Was there a point where you said to yourself I'm going to make a career out of this?

JB: Yes but it was much, much later than you would think. I'd been doing it for a very long time. I would say, let's see, it was one year before people began to know who I was. 1968, I thought, you know I think I want to really do this. I didn't really define what it was or who I wanted to do it with but that I think was already defined in what I heard and what I felt and the people who played in that kind of an essence. A strong, a kind of a really strong feeling.

MR: Did you do non-musical work before, to make a living, before you kind of jumped into the music thing?

JB: No I mean I was always a musician.

MR: You were always a musician.

JB: Yeah, yeah. I started when I was eleven, so I was working by the time I was twelve.

MR: Can you remember what you made on your first paying gig?

JB: No. I don't. But well there was one that I do remember, because I remember being able to go out and buy a coat, a cashmere coat. This was so long ago, of what would be the — what it would be now I can't imagine. I guess if you would times it by twenty, it would

be maybe about two thousand dollars a week now, what it was then. But that was when I was a teenager. I was still in high school and I was working six nights a week in this club. It was like a Latin club, it was called the Million Dollar Theater and we played Latin music. So that was fun. Six nights a week and then I had to try to get to school the next day.

MR: Did your friends think that was pretty outrageous?

JB: Most of them didn't know.

MR: Oh.

JB: Only a few people knew. I didn't tell everybody. Because that was another world that was busy, and then there was the school world.

MR: Yeah. Were you anxious to get out of public school?

JB: I didn't really think school had much value for me after the age of ten or eleven. I had a few teachers that I did like, and I liked the way they taught, and that's what intrigued — I wouldn't care what the subject was, there were a few teachers, but not too many. Most of it I thought was kind of a waste of time.

MR: So the pull of New York eventually got you I would imagine?

JB: Yes. Well I was married then and my husband was from New York.

MR: Charles?

JB: And he wanted to come back, yeah. So we came back and we already had three children so we brought them back and then I had a fourth one here.

MR: Was it culture shock?

JB: No. No. It felt like that's where I should have been from the beginning. Even though I love California, it's beautiful, and being by the ocean, I have to be by the water. Even now you look out my apartment window and you see water. And I also have a beach house that reminds me of the place I was born. And it's on the east coast but you know it's kind of like I need both of those things: the busy, busy city and the very, very quiet by the ocean.

MR: Do you think there is a west coast sound for jazz? You kind of always see that in the history books.

JB: Well you know I mean the people that I heard probably because there was more west coast jazz. Friends introduced me to — I was talking to Chico Hamilton who teaches at the New School, telling him he was one of my first influences because it was Gerry Mulligan and Chet Baker and this is what I used to hear a lot of when I was say fifteen. I didn't hear Bird until I was about seventeen, sixteen or seventeen. So yeah, I like that sound, and it did sound different. And Stan Getz was another one that I heard a lot of in California. So yeah, it did sound a lot different than the other thing, but I like them all. Every tune. I like a lot of different things.

MR: It's interesting because some of those things early on seem to have come out in your playing and compositions, the Latin thing and—

JB: Also I think, I don't know what percentage, but I have some Spanish in me on my father's side, so that I don't know whether — well California has a lot of people who speak Spanish. They are not Spanish, they are more Mexican, but of course I had a lot of friends like that.

MR: Was it difficult raising children in New York?

JB: At the time you know we just made it. We just made it. There was a few schools left and you kind of had to give an address of a friend to get them in the right schools that were left. But just about the time they graduated I would say that it would be very difficult to raise them now, and school them the way that you want them schooled without a whole lot of money. It would have to be done privately. Things may change, but it was on the cusp. I had to move them from the school they should have gone to to one that was good. And they made it through.

MR: What's it like trying to — what year was this now? In the 60s you came here?

JB: I came here in the 60s yeah.

MR: To break in — well the 60s, maybe you can tell me as far as the decades for jazz, the 60s wasn't one of the healthiest I don't think.

JB: Oh it was very innovative.

MR: But as far as finding work, was it hard for you to find work here in New York?

JB: Well I was working with Art Blakey so—

MR: You couldn't have done much better than that.

JB: There was a lot of loft scenes around, and a lot of just sessions. People — I remember working in a club that didn't pay anything but somehow I got hooked up with Pete LaRoca Sims and Dave Liebman and there was — if I could remember the name of the club, they'd know, La Boehme. We worked there six nights a week and Dave Holland used to come down. There was a lot of us that just — we would play, we would get paid something but not what you would consider very much. There was a lot of playing going on, innovative playing. People had their own signatures. They had their own, you know, everybody didn't sound like one person, where we have a tendency now, that a lot of people tend toward that, not that that's bad.

MR: Do you think that, this is a point I was hoping to get to eventually so here we are, do you think that tendency for people to kind of sound like each other is because of the education that's going on now or what is that about?

JB: I'm not sure. I heard from historians that in art, there are certain periods that take place in finance, there are certain periods that take place, there's periods where innovators are born and this goes out and moves in a certain way, and then after maybe eighty years or a

hundred and twenty years, whatever that cycle is, it seems to begin again. If you do a study, which I haven't had the time but I do have the interest, in looking back at the cycles that's hard to do though. Because our cycles now would be — the Internet and the computer are moving much differently. They are just speeded up so fast. I mean knowledge doubles every two or two and a half years, something like that. So it's very exciting to be here now. But to answer that question, you know, there's going to be another group. Life runs in cycles. And it's nice to enjoy that cycle that we're in. It's quite amazing. But I'm glad that I was there in the cycle that I was in, there were a lot of what we call really innovators, people really seriously listening to their own voice. That comes first. The spiritual aspect, and naturistical too, coming first.

MR: Jazz seems to move pretty fast in its development it seems like. Guys like Miles who just, when the audience catches up with him, he's on to something else.

JB: Um hum yeah. It works that way.

MR: Yeah, I guess it does. How did the gig with Blakey come about?

JB: Oh, that's an interesting story. I lived right around the corner from this club called Slug's.

MR: Oh, Slug's, I've heard this name, yes.

JB: A tiny club. I mean it was bigger than this room, but not that much. It had sawdust all over the floor and you could get a beer for a dollar, and all the major groups were there. Art Blakey, Freddie Hubbard, McCoy Tyner, everybody, Lee Morgan. Everybody worked in there. And I lived right around the corner. So but I lived up like six flights of stairs, and I had four kids in five years, and they were very young, so I didn't get out too often. So one night I heard that Art Blakey was there and I though oh I've got enough energy, I'm going to go around and see the band. So I'm saying this because I was kind of spaced out. It was late at night, and I also got up early in the morning. So I walked in there, and here was Art's band. And they just sounded incredible. It was amazing music. And the piano player was sitting up there but he wasn't playing. And it sounded like he should have been playing, it sounded like they needed the piano to play, you know, with the energy that they were playing in right there. So because I'm so spaced out, I'm just only hearing the music, I walked up to the bandstand and say, "Do you mind if I play?" And the piano player said, "No, go ahead." It sounds funny but if you ever have four kids and you're going six flights of stairs up and down for everything you're doing during the whole day, by the time you get to the music it's just, you're so happy that you forget. And that's what happened. And at the end of the set he looked up and saw me and I was hired. It was the furthest thing from my mind.

MR: Oh, that's fantastic. Who was in the band at that point?

JB: I'm trying to remember. Carlos Garnett was in there. I haven't heard him in a long time but I see he had a record out, I think it was last year, a new CD out. Actually the tour we

did Etta Jones was on but she wasn't singing there. The bass player changed. It was Skip Crumby-Bey, but it changed to Jan Arnet, someone from Czechoslovakia that we only saw then. Of course we did go through several bass players and different people. And I think it was Randy Brecker, but he didn't do some of the tours with us. We had Bill Hardman and we also had Woody Shaw, and other tenor players came in later, Ramon Morris, I think Buddy Terry did one job with him. So it was kind of a moving group.

MR: He had a lot of energy, that band, didn't he?

JB: Yeah, he did. It was just like a jungle, it was great.

MR: Did he encourage you to write for the band?

JB: He was always telling me to write for the band but so was Stan Getz and I think that the only people that wanted to play my music were the rhythm sections. It was a long time before horn players came in and wanted to play. I think maybe one of the first was Mike Brecker. He's on one of my first albums. He loved it. And then after that, now I have no problem. Not that everyone wants to do that but there is maybe five or six people that really — I've had Greg Osby do some things, Javon Jackson, Ravi Coltrane, Chris Potter was on one album, so, and there's more, I don't want to forget them but I can't think of everyone at once. But in those days mainly the trios just wanted to play my music. So Stan tried a few times. Then what he did was actually feature the trio at the beginning of each set and we would play.

MR: Now he was not a music reader, was he? He could read some?

JB: He could read, I heard he didn't but he could.

MR: Okay. Maybe he preferred not to.

JB: My tunes were a little bit more than what he wanted to get into.

MR: Right. How is it different playing behind him than with Blakey? Did you feel—

JB: Well it was two totally different things. I mean with Art Blakey you felt like you had a jungle power every time you played. It was incredible. With Stan it was much more sensitive. You had to really listen to every note. It was like playing with a singer. You know, you had to play all the right notes, all the right voicings, play just the time he wanted to hear, and he never said that but you could tell from the way he was playing. And with Stan I just got so very spoiled because he played so in pitch, you know his pitch was so perfect it really bothered me a long time afterward to play with anyone who wasn't aware of — they could play out of the pitch but if they didn't know, if they couldn't play around with it and know where that center was, and I'm the same way with singers, so I became that way then with horn players.

MR: That's an interesting statement about playing behind singers. What do you tell, do you have advice for piano players when they are going to have to branch out into that kind of accompaniment scene?

JB: Well I think now you just go tell them to buy ten CD's of your favorite singer and listen to the piano player. Because that's the best way to actually hear what the possibilities are. It's much easier than the way we had to learn hit and miss.

MR: Yeah.

JB: But you have to hear everything, you don't want to put something just before — every little hair matters, everything matters. It has to be relaxed and swinging too. It's a lot of balance is going on and you just need to know that plus the harmonies and the lines. There's a lot to it.

MR: Have you had occasion where you've tried experimenting with maybe some substitutions and so forth with different singers, and you find that — not to do it.

JB: Well I don't really play with singers but you know the first thing that I always tell, and not everyone does this so you don't have to do this, you know the way Herbie was playing behind Miles. Sometimes it sounds, he's just got his rhythmic thing, and it's so much fun, seemingly having nothing to do with Miles you know. So you could play that way too. He was hooking up a lot with the rhythm section and I'm sure that's what Miles wanted at that time, if we're thinking back into the mid-60s. But I always, when I'm playing behind someone I just hear what notes they're going to use and what notes they're not going to use, and I'm certainly not going to play things that are going to offend that. I'll stretch it as far as I can go but not — to make it sound like one thing.

MR: You've had pretty good success it seems with your recording career. Is it a challenge? Is it difficult to get records out and has it changed over the years?

JB: Well I have a contract now so we've done four and we're — I don't know how many more we'll do. It's a long deal so probably there'll be a lot more coming out. But if I look back over the ones as a leader that I've done I do on average one a year. Because I think I started in 1975, so there's about 25 out. That's the average. That's the way it works out. There's more than one some years, and—

MR: Do you do your own business, I guess, pretty much?

JB: Well I have a manager. You know I work with people and yeah, I get some help. Because you know when you're touring it's too hard, even with the — well I have to get a palm pilot, that's what I think, so I can get the e-mail. I don't have that yet. I just got a new computer. But even at that it's a little difficult sometimes to keep up with things. You let too many things slide that you really want to do. So it's good to have some people supporting you.

MR: Is it somewhat easier now that your kids are grown?

JB: Oh yeah. Of course, yes.

MR: I had a couple of things people have said about you. And Bill Dobbins at Eastman, he said your, "Approach to playing is unique especially in regards to rhythmic development." Does that strike you as a good statement do you think?

JB: I guess so. I mean that's me. I would have to agree that he's certainly — my students use so many of his transcriptions in learning things and learning how to play. There are some key things that he's done, been a transcriber of, so he does a close study of people and things. So I highly regard him and respect him.

MR: Good. This one is a little funny. It's from the *CD Guide to Jazz* and it says, "Her chord voicings are quite dense but this music is strangely accessible." Is that a left handed compliment? Isn't that interesting.

JB: Well I guess he probably just thought, I don't know, it's hard to make that out because you don't know if he's saying that the chords are dense in this or maybe they're not dense in this. And also from about 1995 on up to now, 2001, the harmonies have worked in a lot more and also rhythms and time meters. There is a lot more going on in the music now than there was before, where you can so-called get away with almost anything you want to do. Not anything, but a lot. A lot more. It's a lot more acceptable to play now like I did in 19— let's see when I did that one for Columbia "Tappan Zee," 1979, 1980, I go back and listen to those about once every five years, and that playing is what people are doing now. So it's okay to do that now. So maybe that's what's happening. I don't know what the phenomenon might be.

MR: Playing, as you describe almost anything, if your students were playing something and you thought they had no basis for what they were doing, is there a point where you want them to at least have some grounding? I'm not asking this very well. I'm trying to think, playing outside, but still knowing what you're outside from. Does that make any sense?

JB: Yeah, yeah, yeah. They have to — sometimes usually if they do that it's the rhythmical sense that isn't developed that much. And so I bring them in and make sure that they can do that too. But I never stop them from doing what they're doing. Because I think you can learn in many different realms, you know, points of view at one time. And if a person has started developing one thing, they're very interested in that. So to stop that doesn't make sense to me. So I let them keep on unless it's something just totally disastrous. But that seldom happens. But what I'll do is given them examples and show them how important, you know, usually I'll do it through players. You've got so many players, recordings are so available, it's easy to give references, and then they can understand.

MR: Who are your musical — oh, pioneers for you, besides Frankie Carle?

JB: Well he wasn't really a pioneer. My parents had the record and that's how I got that. But the first people like I think I mentioned before that I heard, it was like you know Bird and Bud and Miles and Tommy Flanagan, Arthur Taylor, Max Roach, some of my favorite

370 people. I guess I'm not naming bass players. They change so much. And then we had
371 Paul Chambers later on. So I liked the piano and the sax and drums most, until I started
372 like that.
373 MR: You've had some marvelous bass players on your recordings over the years.
374 JB: Yeah. Well when I was in Los Angeles we played, I mean Scott LaFaro was one of the
375 bass players that I played with. Charlie Haden. They were from there. So that was right
376 from the start so that was kind of my expectation was people like that.
377 MR: Is it possible to keep a band together these days?
378 JB: Well you know what you do, or what I do is, you kind of have multiple bands. You find
379 people, maybe two or three people that are really into your music on each instrument.
380 Because people are working in so many different groups and we travel so much, so it's
381 really great when you've got your key people there. But I try to have maybe two people
382 on each instrument, maybe a third. Then if one's not available, they kind of know the
383 vocabulary. Because outside of that it wouldn't work. I'm even going to Tel Aviv next
384 week and I'm lucky because Ira Coleman has been working on and off with me for about
385 ten years, and Dion Parsons is new but he's a friend of Ira's, so he's been working with
386 me for about a year. So it's easy. We call one rehearsal. They already have a good idea of
387 what we might do. And that way, you know, maybe there's twenty-five tunes, maybe
388 we're only going to play fifteen but we can decide, and put something new in there. It's
389 difficult just to get a band and rehearse a set, this, this and, you know.
390 MR: Do you find it different overseas as far as the audience for your music?
391 JB: Well I haven't had too many calls to do that music — no I can't say that, I do do that. I
392 worked at the Jazz Standard every year here and then I kind of work some subterranean
393 clubs because I like to do that. So one club is, they get so many people in the club that
394 they don't advertise.
395 MR: Is that right?
396 JB: It's fun, yeah. And I do that maybe two or three times a year, and then I worked in the
397 main club, the Jazz Standard. We get great reception now. We get great reception also in
398 Europe. So it's hard to say. Sometimes in the European audiences, I mean you can tell
399 they haven't heard this kind of music, whereas in New York it's a great audience, but
400 they are a little more sophisticated — maybe less jumping up and down and like little
401 kids in Europe. That's great but I can't say that one is more appreciative than the other. I
402 think that there's a lot of appreciation. The one thing that does seem to happen more in
403 Europe is there are more venues per the population so the sense of culture and art is, and
404 it's a much older country, they developed more. But we have just great music here. I still
405 prefer our music. You know, our musicians, our music. I was reading articles and hearing

people saying oh the music here is becoming like kind of backwards and it's more creative in Europe. But I don't join that. I'm kind of international. I see it all as one thing.

MR: The term "world music" has entered kind of just as a phrase. And it's amazing how fast things get spread around now with communication. And I like to think of our music as world music too.

JB: Well it is. It is. I know those computers, they really do something.

MR: Did I see you had a part in this "Hundred Fingers?"

JB: Oh, Gold Fingers, yeah. Yeah ten piano players, we go to Japan every other year and they take what they call, what I heard, one token woman each time.

MR: Is that right?

JB: Yeah. And I think it was 1995, I guess that's when it was, I was the token woman. That was great. It was great. We played quite a few concerts in Japan and we went to Korea and then I had my own concert in China, so I just made a nice little debut around there. It was great. We had Hank Jones and Kenny Barron and John Lewis. I'd never really hung out with these people, my idols from when I first started listening to music. And Cedar Walton, they put us together to do duos and it was a lot of fun. Junior Mance, the Blues Brothers, Ray Bryant, Roger Kellaway. I know I'm leaving — Barry Harris — I'm going to leave somebody out. Gene Harris.

MR: I'd like to hear you and Roger together actually.

JB: Oh wow.

MR: I think that would be quite something.

JB: Oh yeah. Well we had some kind of — I don't know whether you call it a metaphysical or — something that happened to me on an airplane. It was really bizarre. And I mentioned it to him and he couldn't believe it because that had happened to him and then I couldn't believe that could happen to anybody else. So we had that connection right away. I remember talking. I think he'll remember it too, because it's something you don't run into. But they put him together with, was it Gene Harris? I think they would couple people together. So I was with Cedar. That's what they liked. And I think they based some on the audience too, you know, with what the audience liked. And they had Roger with Gene Harris. So we didn't stand a chance.

MR: I wanted to play just a bit of one of your tunes here. And maybe you can tell me—
[audio interlude]

MR: It's great.

JB: It was fun.

MR: Now, I'm curious about those thick horn harmonies, how you got that. Because you only had two horns, but are you playing that kind of with them or something?

JB: Well that was "A Dog," written for my dog, my little FiFi. Tujai FiFi Tee Tai Tae was his whole name but his nickname was FiFi.

MR: What was his full name again?

JB: Tujai FiFi Te Tai Tae. So it was a little Yorkie dog. Crazy. A very crazy Yorkie dog. He would, we had loft beds that were about up to the top of the curtain there. And if you were chopping carrots, that was his favorite thing to eat, raw carrots, he'd jump right off the loft. This little tiny dog. I mean a very crazy dog. And the little call at the beginning of the recording, that works for ninety percent of any Yorkies. If you go down the street in New York and see a Yorkie and you want it to turn around and come to you, you do that, in that pitch. They come. I've done it. There's some mad owners too. That was Branford barking.

MR: Oh it was Branford? Well you asked him to do a couple different things then. He was on alto on that thing, right? "And you have to bark—"

JB: You know I didn't do that, no that was Al Foster. Because Al, you know I called Al, I wanted him to be the drummer and there was a tenor — I can't remember who I had, I just know I wanted alto. And you know he said, "Well why don't you get Branford?" I said, "Well he's like tenor." Al says, "No, no, no, I've seen, he has an alto, I've seen it, call him."

MR: He can do it.

JB: So he kept telling me that and finally I did. I didn't know Branford then so I took his word for it, and he did, he didn't have, I remember he didn't have the neck strap, so he was like playing with no neck strap.

MR: No kidding. That's funny. When you write a tune like that, earlier on we had kind of talked about this, is it a result of sitting --

JB: The dog died. So in the evening I'd begin to feel bad and I thought okay I'm going to write a tune for him. And the tune came right out.

MR: Wow.

JB: Very, very simple, but it sounds just exactly like the dog. And it's in four four, which I think is not a problem, but there was a Town Hall concert we played that Randy Brecker and Dave Liebman were the horn players and Pat Martino was on guitar. And they were trying to get this tune. And it was like, no, no, you wrote it wrong, no that's not four four.

MR: You wrote it wrong.

JB: And finally they said yeah it is, but what is this? I never thought of it that way but that's how the dog was, so you know you would never know what he was going to do next.

MR: Wow. You really captured it, huh?

JB: He was just off the wall. Yeah.

MR: Well suppose I wanted to commission you for a new piece of music. And I basically said, "Whatever you want." How do you start the process?

JB: Oh I have a lot of ideas. Whatever you want, that's a pretty big field there. I'd think about it and, you know—

MR: Do you get ideas away from the piano?

JB: Well the ideas come like in a form of energy that doesn't have a form. It's like a feel. And then I go to the piano and it comes out. That's how I translate it. But it's there before I go to the piano. However, the piano is such a great translator, almost equal to going on-line on the computer. How could you get on-line without the computer? That's how the piano is for me. It's like it really makes things very easy. So I write from the piano. But it's already written before I get to the piano.

MR: Interesting. You have a rhythmic feel perhaps?

JB: Well it's hard to define it. It's the whole thing.

MR: You seem to be someone who is always searching for something new to me.

JB: Yeah. I was thinking in the taxi on the way up here, I'm really happy I'm living in these times now. Because I've always been kind of like that, and now the outside world is as crazy as I was on the inside, and I feel good. I feel like really more at home.

MR: Oh, that's very interesting.

JB: It is. Yeah. It certainly is.

MR: The world caught up with you.

JB: With whatever it was in me, I don't know.

MR: Are you a technical oriented person.

JB: No. But I don't have anything against it.

MR: You still like to write your music with a pen?

JB: I do. I have the computer now that will work that way easily, I just got it last week so I probably will end up having to do it the other way, that's for sure. But naturistically yeah, I like to just write it out.

MR: What's coming up in the future. I know you're going to Israel you said.

JB: Yeah. And then I'm going to do a concert in Toronto. It's like a solo concert but it's two of us, it's Junior Mance doing solo and myself. And then I'll work a week at a Montreal Bistro.

MR: Neat.

JB: And then I start my teaching at Berklee College of Music. I go straight from Toronto there. And then I have some college dates coming up, Smith College and some of my underground New York dates and then once again the Jazz Standard and a possible tour of Europe in July. Things are starting to fill in now.

MR: The majority of—

JB: New Orleans too.

MR: New Orleans too?

JB; I do that once a year.

MR: Neat.

JB: It should be in March.

MR: Do you find most of your colleagues do some educational type gigs?

JB: A lot of them do, yeah. A lot of them do. In fact that's how I get inspired to do it. It was Cecil McBee that told me about students in Boston. Because he teaches at the New England Conservatory and Berklee had called me up there to do a concert. And there was a clinic right before the concert. And it was an unbelievable clinic. I got these great questions, which I had never gotten before in a clinic. So then they called me to do a residency, but I was like, I can't go there three days a week, no. So I told them I would do a half of a residency. So they found somebody. It took them about six months, but they found someone else to split it with. So I did that, and after I did that it was great teaching. I had just really great students. So I told them if they wanted I would teach one day a week if that would work in their program. And it did. So now I do one and a half days a week.

MR: You actually commute?

JB: Yeah. Oh I wouldn't move from New York.

MR: Right.

JB: No.

MR: The city I guess has a certain energy that's just right for what you do.

JB: Yeah I don't know why I like it, I just do.

MR: Is it possible to tell students something extra to prepare themselves to make a living with this kind of music?

JB: Well they should be very serious about the music and if they are a student in school that's what they really should be delving into. At the same time they should be thinking where they would like to present this music, how they would like to present it too. I don't really teach that but if they ask me I certainly try to help them. A lot of them just want to teach as well, and then some want to perform. I try to just prepare them for what it is they think they want to do. I don't tell them what they should do or what they want to do. I just kind of let them be the guide.

MR: Are there musicians out there that would be on your wish list to either record with or for you to hire?

JB: Well I just saw Russell Malone downstairs. We were, Bob at Arcadia, Bob Carsey and I were talking about maybe doing a duet album at some point. Not right now but at some

point. And I knew I wanted Russell, to do one with Russell. Another one might be Sonny Rollins. I haven't talked with him yet though. That would be really fun. I would like that.

MR: He's kind of a — I'm not sure what word to use — you don't hear that much from him and then he comes out with another album.

JB: Yeah. He's great. Another person I really like is the couple Chick and Gayle.

MR: Chick Corea and Gayle—

JB: Yeah, I really like them. I'd like to do something with them.

MR: You know, I didn't even know, are they still together and working.

JB: Oh yeah.

MR: Oh I hadn't heard that.

JB: Well I see them usually here in New York, with some bass with them.

MR: You have any kind of spiritual connection with your music?

JB: Well I've always been like into metaphysics, and it wasn't until after my grandmother died that they finally told me she was a metaphysician.

MR: You know you're going to have to explain what you mean by that for me.

JB: Metaphysicians? That's somebody who does, the visualize, they can image certain things, either for themself or someone else, and the thing will take place. And it could be something really bizarre. But if they get the feeling of it and they can see it, it happens. So I think I just picked that up from my grandmother without even knowing. So I do a lot of things in that way without even knowing, expecting everyone to understand what I'm doing and how I'm doing it. And I think little kids, that's why I feel really close with little kids, because they can do that. I'm always looking at them. Even the little kids, on Channel 13, the little kiddies program, they hardly even talk, so it's got to be like one year old. They've got a program for little kids. And I'm like ten minutes watching this program. I don't know there's something, it's nonverbal but it's very, very definite, and it brings results in the visible world. So I love things like that. That's one of my hobbies.

MR: What kind of reading do you like to do?

JB: Well that's —

MR: That's a big part of it?

JB: That would be it. That it would just be mostly. I like some biographies too, but if someone comes up with something I'll read it. I don't go searching for things. There's so many things to do.

MR: I know you've already said that this is the time for you. In New York, this is the time.

JB: I can't say — ten years from now I might think it's even more or less, but—

MR: Is there a time in history, going back as far as you'd like, that you would have liked to participate in?

JB: I don't know, maybe the time Michelangelo and the time these people that did many, many things at one time, and they also lived long, some of them lived long lives and they had a chance to really get into a lot of different fields and things. Maybe. I don't know. I like it now.

MR: Good.

JB: So I don't want to go back in history. But it's exciting.

MR: Being in this hotel right now crawling with jazz musicians and educators and everything, it kind of skews this question perhaps, but how do you feel about the health of jazz these days and for the future?

JB: Well people are healthier while they play it.

MR: People are healthier, uh huh.

JB: Less things that are — you know, but we know more about the body too, so that's kind of nice. The energy is better. And a lot of people learn so fast in the schooling, these kids learn so fast. It would be nice if we could, well you know, try to balance the inner knowledge, I think that's the thing that has to happen now because we're kind of going for the outer knowledge and at some point it's just like the NASDAQ dropping way down. I think we have to get that together with the inner knowledge so that the human knowledge gets associated fully with the musical knowledge. But it's taking place. It's very interesting. Well when I went to hear Chick he had just gotten an e-mail from an eight year old boy, I didn't hear the end of the story, Chick was going up to Boston to play, but this little boy, or he was seven years old, he had transcribed like Chick's solos and he could play them, and then he could do free improvisation. So he sent an e-mail with some of his free improvising. And Chick said it sounded very mature, really great. So they were going to meet in Boston. That's where the little boy lived. So it's like they were ten and twelve, well the Monk competition was won by a ten year old in third place.

MR: Is that right?

JB: Yeah Latin percussion. Ten years old. That was this year. And then Maria Schneider was telling me, we did some big band, we split a big band concert, and she was telling me about this horn player from Sicily that was like ten or eleven years old, just kind of leading this whole band and having incredible knowledge of how to make the rhythm section, which was not together, sound like it was together. And I'm like okay it was teenagers, now they're going down into the single digits. Like the wind chill this winter.

MR: Yeah, wow. You wonder if they're not possessing someone's spirit from—

JB: It's very interesting. Exciting.

MR: Well is there anything I haven't asked you that you'd like to talk about?

JB: I like to swim.

MR: You like to swim.

JB: I just had a swimming class yesterday. That was fun. Kind of cold for a while, I kind of did it.

MR: Well you said you like to be near the water, so it keeps you healthy. I know you've done Marian McPartland's show.

JB: A couple of times. She's a good friend. She's always calling. She's an amazing person. Always sending me articles, she does this with people, sends them articles on themselves that they never would have seen. She's unbelievable, as well as getting better at the piano. I think she's playing this week at the, it's part of Lincoln Center, where they have duets. The Penthouse.

MR: Oh, right.

JB: Yes. Near here.

MR: They have a nice piano there as a matter of fact.

JB: Oh. I tried to go when Joe Lovano and Gonzalo were there but it was totally sold out both nights so.

MR: Wow. Well we can only hope that we'll be that vital when we get that age I think. She was at Hamilton in September. She did a great show.

JB: Fantastic, yeah.

MR: Well I wish you a lot of luck in your travels.

JB: Well thank you.

MR: And I hope you keep writing, you have a very distinctive sound to your work.

JB: Oh thank you, thanks. Well I have two new CDs, they're not out yet, and they both have new compositions on them. One I recorded live at the Jazz Standard that was with Negro, my regular drummer and Ira Coleman and Ravi Coltrane. And then I did a CD that was very interesting, Latin American music but world Latin American. Like some from Spain, some from Cuba, from Chile, from Brazil, from all over, and that's like featuring Paquito as one of the guests on there and Farid Haque is playing guitar, with Negro once again and Sante Dibriano is on bass. So we're doing all these different tunes, and some of them were difficult for me, just to transcribe, to give them, like to transcribe for guitar, for piano, and to get that to sound right. But I did do some originals on all of these.

MR: Is the Latin music of so many different places rhythmically, it's all a little different, isn't it?

JB: Yeah.

MR: It must take some study and absorbing before you can play.

JB: I can hear a lot further than what I can play. But Negro was so perfect. He can do anything I write, anything I do, he's just right there. Just right on it. So it was a lot of fun. And those should come out this year so I'm looking forward to that. It would be fun to tour doing some of that music. And Paquito knew everything. These tunes that I thought

were really, I mean I went to Hawaii and they had this one tune. Nobody would know that, no piano anywhere near that with a singer. And he says, "Oh that's — I know that, yeah." And he started playing. He knew every tune I had on the album. Nobody knows all of it. But Bob Carsey was responsible for getting this music to me. You know, "Joanne, I think, listen to this one," you know, he gave me a whole album to listen to. Some Piazzola, all different things.

MR: Now there's a name that seems to be on the hot list these days.

JB: Oh boy, yeah. So he came up with these great tunes. So that was a learning experience for me.

MR: Well it's been a pleasure to meet you. And I wish you the best.

JB: Thank you. It's been great being here and I'm glad to be a part of your series.

MR: Good. Thanks so much.

JB: Okay. You're welcome.